

think we could have survived with it. Hitting the ball through the legs (laughs), I don't think I could have done that, or hitting over the head. But watching these present-day cricketers and how they have adapted to this kind of cricket, sometimes I wonder whether we — or I — could have done that. Seven to eight decades is a long time, and I came across great cricketers — not only from India but abroad as well. That was a tremendous satisfaction.

It's well documented that Vijay Hazare was one of the biggest influences on you.

In three different eras, I was closely involved with three great cricketers. I was their mentee, manager, and selector. For instance, Mr. Vijay Hazare was a huge influence on me. Cricketing-wise, I learned a lot watching him because I bowled to him in the nets playing for Baroda; that was the first decade. And what a fantastic batsman! For me, he was the best in that era.

Later on came Sunil Gavaskar. The way he batted against the fast bowlers without a helmet, without protective gear, and getting so many runs was phenomenal. That's the second decade.

And the third decade or era was Sachin Tendulkar, when I managed the team on his first tour with the Indian team. These three great players performed very well for the country and for the cricket fraternity.

Can you recall the most memorable incident with each of these three people?

The first incident took place at Baroda during the Ranji Trophy final against Services, captained by Colonel (Hemu) Adhikari in 1957–58. Mr. Hazare was with the Indian team at that time, around 40 years old. Services planned meticulously to dismiss him promptly. Being a military man, Colonel Adhikari instructed the fast bowler Surendranath to deliver a bouncer on the off-stump as soon as Mr. Hazare came to bat. We noticed their preparation during the two days of practice before the final. As soon as

Mr. Hazare entered at No. 4, Surendranath executed the plan with a beautiful bouncer. Mr. Hazare attempted to hook, missed, and the ball went to mid-on, where the fielder dropped the catch. Colonel Adhikari went and told the fielder, "Don't worry, boy, you will get the next chance when he scores 200." True to his words, Mr. Hazare scored a double hundred, and our partnership was around 100 runs (147). It was a tremendous learning experience to watch him.

Moving on to Sunil Gavaskar... I had the privilege of being a selector when he made his Test debut [in



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1971]. More than a decade later, after drawing [the fifth Test] with England in Kanpur in February 1985, the team was set to tour Australia for the Benson & Hedges Trophy. I was the chairman of the selection committee, and we had decided to make Sunil the captain. But I heard that he may announce his retirement, and I didn't want him to do that. I visited his room one evening and we chatted over a cup of tea. I told him, "When you come back after winning the Benson & Hedges Trophy, don't announce retirement or give up captaincy." He responded with a wry smile, leaving us uncertain. He indeed gave up captaincy after winning the final, where Ravi Shastri won the Audi. That marked the second incident.

The third incident occurred in Sialkot during Sachin's tour with the Indian team. As the manager, I witnessed Sachin being hit by a bouncer, causing bleeding. I went to the ground, suggesting we go back to the dressing room for treatment.



However, Sachin insisted, "No, sir, I am going to play." The physio arrived and managed the bleeding. Sachin wore his helmet and promptly hit three clear boundaries. We were all surprised, and I was sure he was going to stay there for a long time.

Can you recall the 2007 Test series win in England when you were appointed as Cricket Manager during a turbulent phase?

We won a series in England after 21 years, and still, it didn't get that much recognition. (Rahul) Dravid was the captain. That was a very good victory. Just before that, the team had lost